

KF36 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

We will continue with the **Lectio Divina**.

Assume a meditation posture. Scan your body for tension, and relax on the exhale. Collect yourself and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

1. Read the passage

I will read a short sentence from the Bible and then pause. Our encouragement is from Hebrews 12:1.

*Let us run with endurance the challenge set before us.
(Repeat) (Pause)*

2. Receive as you listen

Relax while I read this Scripture three times, pausing between readings. Take the attitude of a listener. In the stillness between the readings, consider your experience with the words and allow a related feeling, thought, or image to come to mind. If nothing definite comes, observe the absence of these things or just enjoy the stillness. Observe with compassion any other feelings or thoughts that may intrude, and then return to the text. Let's begin. *(Use the singular pronoun for the last reading)*

*Let us (me) run with endurance the challenge set before us (me).
(Read the passage 3 times, pausing for 30 seconds after each reading)*

3. Respond

Respond to God with affirmation and gratitude. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

4. Rest in awareness

Rest in stillness for one minute as you contemplate what you have experienced during this time. You might allow the phrase to gently recede and refocus your mind on your breath. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause and re-engage with your environment. You may wish to take this next minute to record your

experience in a KF journal or on your **Meeting Preparation Guide**, or you might simply wait. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause. You can use this meditation to explore any passage from the Bible that feels meaningful to you. Read the Scripture out loud and savor it for ten or fifteen minutes. Let God reorient your spirit with the truth of the words.

At the games in ancient Greece, the judges awarded a crown to the winner of a contest. With that thought in mind, listen to our hymn for KF Confession 8, *And Can It Be?*

No condemnation now I dread.
Jesus, and all in Him, is mine.
Alive in Him, my living Head,
And clothed in righteousness divine.
Bold I approach the eternal throne
And claim the crown, through Christ my own!
Bold I approach the eternal throne
And claim the crown, through Christ my own!¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

In KF Confession 8, we state our intention to cooperate with God in His effort to recover and develop our True Self:

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

Children do not innately have the courage to deny themselves a treat or to go into a dark place. They are designed to be egocentric for their survival, and they need training in oriented behavior. Their perceptions are rarely based on reality. One of the most striking characteristics of children is that they are weak in endurance. Most people have not learned the great rewards of endurance because they give up too soon in their training. Like children, they are still motivated by instant gratification, snatching at what they hope to gain and losing heart when their goals are not quickly realized. They long for a shortcut that will relieve their tension, even if that shortcut leads them deeper into chaos. They cannot imagine how practicing endurance might benefit them, and their lack of skill prevents them from discovering what marvelous outcomes are possible if they would learn to endure. The process of building strong CORE muscles requires time, and while we are building those muscles, we will have to learn endurance.

We may not think of ourselves as people who need instant gratification, but *instant* is a matter of perception. For a young person, enduring something for a few years seems like forever, so it may be harder for them than for older people to allow endurance to accomplish its oriented outcome. For an older, wiser, and trained person, enduring productively for a few years is a worthwhile investment because he or she knows by experience that a few years of effort and endurance can reap wonderful rewards.

1. Mindfulness practice and meditation teach us productive endurance

The practice of mindfulness and meditation helps us develop the CORE muscle of endurance. In KF meetings we learn to take small mindfulness steps, but we hope that each one of you will go on to take bigger steps and increase your meditation time. When you practice mindfulness and meditation, your mind and body must endure the self-criticism, anxiety, frustration, and wiggles of boredom that come with learning any new skill. If you learn to endure these tensions, you will increase your capacity to endure tension in other challenging situations. You are presently learning the skill of mindful endurance by practicing meditation in a quiet environment where there are few distractions. This skill can then be applied in far more distracting and stressful circumstances. You must learn to sail on a sheltered lake before launching out onto the ocean.

I wonder if during your meditation time you have ever had these thoughts: *I can't do this. I can't do it right. I don't want to be doing this. I am too [. . .] to do this. This isn't working. I'm a failure. This doesn't help. I'm too tired. I'm wasting my time. I've got a dozen other things to do. I wish I were doing something else. I'm an idiot for thinking that this will help. Will the timer never ring? How can I get out of this right now? I'm so bored!* It's quite natural to think and feel this way. Learning to meditate requires endurance—and aren't these exactly the kind of thoughts and feelings you have in any place of endurance? The untrained parts of you are being stretched, and they have lots of strong feelings about that! The Idol Self uses these feelings to discourage you from developing the endurance you need to become real and glorious. The Idol takes pride in effortless superiority, so it hates any form of endurance or effort.

2. Listening to another person teaches us productive endurance

The practice of listening attentively during the sharing and teaching times trains you to endure productively. As egocentric neurotics, we are very unwilling to give the gift of authentic attention to another person. We are bored, or we want to react and draw the attention back to ourselves. We want to fix, judge, guide, or avoid. Some people listen as a means of supporting their idealized self; they are not really hearing the other person at all. They listen to protect themselves from exposure and avoid dealing with their own life. Others enjoy temporary relief from their anxiety and self-hate when another person talks to them; in that moment they feel valued. For some people, listening is like watching TV—what they see or hear is more interesting than their own life.

The practice of listening attentively trains you to endure productively and gives you the creative mental space to develop and exercise your boundaries. You learn how to protect your time, your energy, and your business when people want to abuse you with incessant talking and the egocentric display of their thoughts and feelings.

The skill of listening to others can be applied to ourselves when we are talking. As you are speaking, learn to listen to yourself so that you hear what others hear. Mindfully listening to yourself helps you communicate in a way that is authentic and also comfortable for your listeners. You can learn how to be aware, intentional, and mindful when someone is talking—and that includes God and yourself. God often tells us to listen up. He isn't kidding!

3. Practicing endurance trains us for life's difficulties

Without training in productive endurance, you will find it much more difficult to manage your anxiety and respond to life's experiments with orientation. Your business is to practice endurance and give it a chance to accomplish the oriented outcome of developing virtue and a trustworthy character.² Whenever you meditate, pray, or listen to others, you strengthen the core muscle of endurance. If

you haven't learned to endure, you will always be looking for ways to escape the training opportunities that God is presenting to you. Life is difficult, and if you cannot endure for even a few minutes, how can you hope to endure for the long run?

If you are suffering and finding it hard to endure, try working through the worksheet **Suffering: An Opportunity to see Yourself**, and bear in mind that you may be inflicting suffering on yourself. We are often reluctant to examine our own suffering because that suffering serves our neurotic goals—our Idol Self is getting something out of it. For example, you might use your suffering to punish and manipulate so that you and others “do better” next time. Suffering can also be a convenient excuse to avoid responsibility or to avoid working on your own healing. Perhaps you use suffering to make yourself and others feel guilty. You can then extort support, sympathy, attention, and admiration. You may sometimes need to make your experience unendurable so that you can justify a precipitous escape.

When we refuse to honor our limitations and those of others, we cause our own suffering. We demand that those around us support our illusions, and we feel cheated or discouraged if we meet obstacles. Hoping that God will miraculously pull us through, we overload ourselves with more and more activities, stuff, work, debt, and commitments. We push, shove, and force to the point of exhaustion and to the detriment of our health and are unwilling to learn to be patient in our discomfort. Instead, we cling to the belief that we are like gods and can get what we want if we push hard enough. Then, if our circumstances are not magically transformed, we blame God or others for our suffering. In our karis relationship with God, however, suffering becomes an invitation to acknowledge our limitations and train our ability to live in reality.

If you refuse training, you simply will not have the strength to productively endure adversity. Under stress, you will default to old habits of saving your life, and you will cause more suffering. Your Idol has loaded you with the baggage of its misorientation, and that heavy weight prevents you from running your race with endurance. In Karis Fellowships, we are working hard to unload this extra weight and to strengthen our capacity to endure. We want to run.

Worksheets and KF meetings will help you unload the weight that keeps you from enduring your race. Hopefully you have been using your KF worksheets. To further integrate what you learn into your whole person, attend KF meetings regularly. Meetings help you unload the baggage that lies below your consciousness. Although listening to recordings and reading the **Expanded Version** notes is very helpful, you might not get the same results if you are not present in the meeting. Preparing for the meeting, sharing, confessing, and connecting to the energy of an orienting group all work together for your orientation.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord of an easy yoke, I am willing and ready to unload the Idol's weight.³ (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 8 encourages us to get into training with God:

We co-labor with the Creator to seek and to save that which was lost.

Turn in your Bibles to the book of Hebrews, which falls right before James. People in the first century were trained to remember the context of a portion of Scripture. Following that tradition, I have incorporated ideas from chapter 11 in my paraphrase of **Hebrews 12:1–17**. As you listen to the text for this lesson, notice how the author uses the words *endurance*, *discipline*, and *training*.

¹When we consider all those who have gone before us into a better country—those who acted on their beliefs and who already know by experience what we are coming to know—we are encouraged to keep moving toward that country set apart for us by God. Therefore, lay aside the heavy weight of the Idol Self and its misorientation, which so easily entangles us. Let us run with endurance the challenge stretching out before us and ²fix our sights on the beacon light of Jesus, who by the example of His choices leads us forward. He accomplished the goal of showing us the way home. He endured the cross and exchanged it for joy. He resisted self-hate and took His place of authority next to the throne of God. That is your path, too. ³You might consider this: Jesus, our Lord and leader, endured the same kinds of misoriented people that you endure—people who resist the person of Jesus in their thoughts and choices. His example encourages us not to abandon our True Self or become weary in our efforts.

⁴Let's get real. You can still do better in your striving against misorientation. Your efforts haven't killed you yet! ⁵You have forgotten the firm guidance that is addressed to you as sons: "My son, do not undervalue the discipline of God, believing that it's not worthwhile, and do not faint when He corrects you, judging that His correction and discipline are too hard and unfair. ⁶Why do we engage with His training? Because God only disciplines those whom He loves, and every son that He receives as a candidate for training He thoroughly corrects."

⁷You endure in order to be trained. In other words, your training requires your endurance. God is dealing with you as He would deal with sons. Think about this: What kind of father would not train his own son? ⁸Everyone has received some sort of training, but if you are not trained by God, then you are not of God's lineage—you are not His son. ⁹Before we were accepted as sons of God, we were trained by fathers of our material lineage, and we turned toward their way of doing things, which did not help us much. We would do better to come under the management of the Father of our spiritual lineage, and live. ¹⁰Let me explain what I mean. Our material fathers trained us for a short time according to what they thought was best, but often not according to what we needed. God, however, trains us according to what would benefit us now and profit us in the better country that He has set apart for us. ¹¹For all training seems grievous and difficult rather than fun. But if we make our training an exercise in orientation, it will eventually reward us with the fruit of peace.

¹²That being the case, restore to action the hands that have given up out of exhaustion and set straight the knees that are wobbling from effort. ¹³Stop wasting your energy in bad training that causes exhaustion and wobbling. Get going in the right direction so that you can heal your ability to work and to run.

¹⁴Pursue peace with everyone and work toward achieving a life set apart in orientation and truth. No one will be able to see the Lord in you if you do not achieve that kind of life.

¹⁵Keep a watch on yourselves and see that no one dawdles behind in their karis relationship with God. Make sure that no one allows a root of bitterness to sprout up where karis should be sprouting up; bitter roots cause trouble and defile many.

¹⁶Watch over yourselves and see that no sexually untrustworthy persons dwell among you—people who allow themselves to be trodden on by cravings and defilement. Esau was a person like that. He exchanged his precious firstborn rights for simple food, just because he could not endure a little discomfort. ¹⁷You know how that turned out. Even afterwards, when Esau wished to inherit favor and the blessing, he was rejected as a candidate because he had shown himself unworthy to be a son. As an untrustworthy person, he had refused the karis training. He could not undo the damage he had done even though he sought to do so with tears, because tears are not a substitute for trustworthy action.

Take a deep breath.

This passage is rich in ideas, and I hope that you will take time to explore some of them for yourself. Here is what I would like you to remember.

1. We all have a race to run

Each of us has a different race to run—a contest or challenge that stretches out before us—but the goal is always the same: to develop the character of Jesus in our lives. Jesus is our leader, and He is taking us home. Like Jesus, learn to endure hostility, even if that hostility comes from your own self-hate. It cannot hurt you.

2. We endure tough things because we have a goal

We are in training for our mission and for our joy—and to bring God joy. Our lives are becoming a holy place in a very unholy world. At times, God's training might feel severe, but that is only our perception and not the reality, for we know that the burden Jesus lays upon us is easy, and His yoke is light.⁴ The outcome of His discipline is orientation, and the fruit of orientation is peace. God's goal is to train us to live as citizens of the peaceful and better country that He has set aside for us, circulating with the Creation in harmony with His will and revealing our true glory.

One of the benefits of our training is the discovery of how weak we actually are; we discover how much our misorientation is interfering with our efforts to run with endurance. The oriented use of the emotion of hate furthers our process of sanctification. We learn to hate what is not holy, and we refuse to participate in evil. We are then able to stand in the defense of our True Self and become trustworthy people who cannot be lured into misorientation by the Idol.

3. We can choose to strengthen our own souls for the contest

Your primary contest is against the Idol Self, and the race set before *you* is *your* opportunity to build up *your* soul. Don't dawdle at the starting post out of laziness or the fear of suffering, and don't give up at the first discouraging hurdle. In order to win your contest, you need training, excellent self-care, and the support of God's coaching and discipline. God's discipline can be extremely uncomfortable in the moment, but it is accomplishing something glorious. He is stretching you so that you can live in

the joy of *real-izing* your true potential. Your productive suffering carves the place for joy. Productive suffering turning into joy is one of the cycles of life.⁵

Esau sought with tears the birthright he had rejected. That is a kind of suffering, but it is not productive. We might regret that we have sold out to the Idol Self and lost our birthright as sons of God, but self-pitying regrets will not fulfill our glory. What will fulfill our glory? A karis relationship with God. So, stop crying, and get on with trying! I know that training is hard, but I speak from decades of experience when I say that hard training is worth it. If you have no regrets about the changes you have made in your life through KF, then press on. Don't fall short of the karis gift of God's glory, which invites you to be holy and set apart into truth. From that holy place of truth you are fulfilled, and your life spontaneously reveals the astonishing and marvelous character of our Lord.

We have no reason to fear God's training because He is taking us on a journey to a better country. Let's listen to my paraphrase of Jude's description of God, our Parent and Trainer.

²⁴To Him who, like a watchful parent, has the power to help you avoid falls and, also, to keep you on your feet as you stand before His glory without blemish and with great joy—
²⁵to the only God our Savior through Jesus Christ our Lord be glory, majesty, government, and authority before all the ages, now, and throughout all generations. Amen.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Heavenly Parent, teach me to courageously run my own contest with endurance. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider giving God permission to train you for your contest. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider giving God permission to train you for your contest*, recognize what you are feeling. Notice what is happening inside your skin as you consider giving God this permission. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow your experience to present itself, and welcome that experience into your awareness. You might notice any struggle or tension when you *consider giving God permission to train you for your contest. (Pause)* Welcome whatever information that tension brings. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission to explore, without judgment, whatever you are experiencing. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider giving God permission to train you for your contest*. How does your body respond? *(Pause)* You might notice what fatigue, terror, or even anticipation feels like in your body. You might feel nothing at all. Gently maintain awareness of your body's sensations, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of giving God permission to train you for your contest*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or numb? Just observe. *(Pause)* Could there be fear or resistance—or, perhaps, joy? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider giving God this permission? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Do you fear the loss of some aspect of your Idol's search for glory? Does your need for training hurt your pride? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat to yourself the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore the challenge set before you.
- Welcome the creative Holy Spirit of truth, who finds joy in training you.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁶

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for power and control.
- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for esteem and affection.
- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for security and comfort.
- As You train me for my contest, I let go of my longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for drawing us together as we present ourselves to You for training. Hold us in the power of this orientation and continue to guide us to our glory and truth. Prepare the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our true design and mission, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*If you have the MATH to support the NHG book study, please go to the NHG tab on the KF website and sign up on the NHG Facilitator Signup Spreadsheet.

*(*Except when preparing for Jubilee Year)*

¹ *And Can It Be?* by Charles Wesley (1707–1788), www.youtube.com/watch?v=sQelGbKgiw8.

² See KF3.

³ Matt. 11:28–30.

⁴ Matt. 11:30.

⁵ Psalm 30:5.

⁶ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.